MAXIM SHEVCHENKO'S ORTHODOX CHRISTIAN/SOCIAL PROJECT

The third case study concerns Maxim Shevchenko, born in Moscow in 1966. He is also an offspring of the Soviet Moscow elite (his grandfather was a professor of physics; his father a geophysical-seismologist). In 1990, he graduated from the Moscow Aviation Institute. He also attended lectures in the field of Oriental Studies at the Institute of Asia and Africa at Moscow State University. Between 1993 and 1995, he taught history in the first classical Orthodox school. He has also worked as a journalist since 1987 for the *Messenger of Christian Democracy*, and as a correspondent for "hot spots" (Afghanistan, Pakistan, Chechnya, Dagestan, Yugoslavia, and the Middle East) for the *Independent Newspaper* and as editor-in-chief of its "Religion" supplement. In 2000, he established the Center for Strategic Studies of Religion and Politics of the Modern World. Between 2005 and 2011, his TV show "Judge for Yourself" was broadcast in primetime on Russian TV's Channel One. However, it was closed at the demand of the Russian Jewish Congress because Shevchenko had declared that the terrorist attack by Anders Breivik in Oslo, Norway was the result of his neo-Nazi views and sympathy to Israel.[24] In 2008 and 2010, Shevchenko was a member of the Public Chamber of the Russian Federation nominated by a presidential declaration. He is a member of the Anti-Orange Committee established in 2012 as a framework for various anti-democratic activists who see the current developments in several ex-Soviet republics as an American plot against Russia. He also a member of the Izborsk Club—an intellectual think-tank of nationalist and leftist writers, historians, journalists, and scientists. Such umbrella GONGO (Government Organized NGO) institutions are aggressively loyal to the Putin regime and receive sympathetic treatment from the Kremlin.

Shevchenko combines militant Orthodox Christianity and neo-leftist ideas, asserting the uniqueness of the Russian historical development, along with the adoption of European anti-enlightenment theories applied to the modern situation in Russia. He offers selective criticism of the establishment (especially the financial one) quite often used to camouflage his antisemitic attitudes, strong opposition to western liberalism in favor of the "real people's democracy," glorification of austerity and asceticism (citing, for instance, that of the Taliban leaders and Mahmoud Ahmadinejad) in opposition to the corrupt western elites. Shevchenko idealizes the just social norms and solidarity within religious communities (especially Orthodox Christian and Muslim); he is homophobic, and expresses sympathy for some elements of the Soviet past (for example, internationalism and egalitarianism); of particular note is his Islamophilia.

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Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,